

Sam Altman on AI morality, ethics and finding God in ChatGPT

Altman denies AI is divine, but admits spiritual uncertainty

—By **Jayesh Shinde**

You look hard enough at an AI chatbot's output, it starts to look like scripture. At least, that's the unsettling undercurrent of Sam Altman's recent interview with Tucker Carlson – a 57-minute exchange that had everything from deepfakes to divine design, from moral AI frameworks to existential dread. To his credit, the man steering the most influential AI system on the planet – OpenAI's ChatGPT – Sam Altman wasn't evasive in his response. He was honest, vulnerable, even contradictory at times. Which made his answers all the more illuminating.

"Do you believe in God?" Carlson asked, directly without mincing his words. "I think probably like most other people, I'm somewhat confused about this," Sam Altman replied. "But I believe there is something bigger going on than... can be explained by physics."

It's the kind of answer you might expect from a quantum physicist or a sci-fi writer – not the CEO of a company that shapes how billions of people interact with knowledge. But that's precisely what makes Altman's quiet agnosticism so fascinating. He shows neither theistic certainty, nor waves the flag of militant atheism. He simply admits he doesn't know.

Altman on ChatGPT and AI's moral compass and religion

In another question, Tucker Carlson described ChatGPT's output as having "the spark of life," and suggested many users treat it as a kind of oracle.

"There's something divine about this," Carlson said. "There's something



bigger than the sum total of the human inputs... it's a religion."

Sam Altman didn't flinch when he said, "No, there's nothing to me at all that feels divine about it or spiritual in any way. But I am also, like, a tech nerd. And I kind of look at everything through that lens."

It's a revealing response. Because what happens when someone who sees the world as a system of probabilities and matrices starts programming "moral" decisions into the machines we consult more often than our friends, therapists, or priests?

Altman does not deny that ChatGPT reflects a moral structure – it has to, to some degree, purely in order to function. But he's clear that this isn't morality in the biblical sense.

"We're training this to be like the collective of all of humanity," he explains. "If we do our job right... some things we'll feel really good about, some things that we'll feel bad about. That's all in there."

This idea – that ChatGPT is the average of our moral selves, a statistical mean of our human knowledge pool – is both radical and terrifying. Because when you average out humanity's ethical

behaviour, do you necessarily get what's true and just? Or something that's more bland, crowd-sourced, and neither here nor there?

Altman admits this: "We do have to align it to behave one way or another... there are absolute bounds that we draw." But who decides those bounds? OpenAI? Nation-states? Market forces? A default setting on a server in an obscure datacenter?

On privacy, biometrics, and AI's war on reality

If AI becomes the mirror in which humanity stares long enough to worship itself, what happens when that mirror is fogged, gamed, or deepfaked?

Altman is clear-eyed about the risks: "These models are getting very good at bio... they could help us design biological weapons." But his deeper fear is more subtle. "You have enough people talking to the same language model," he observed, "and it actually does cause a change in societal scale behaviour."

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